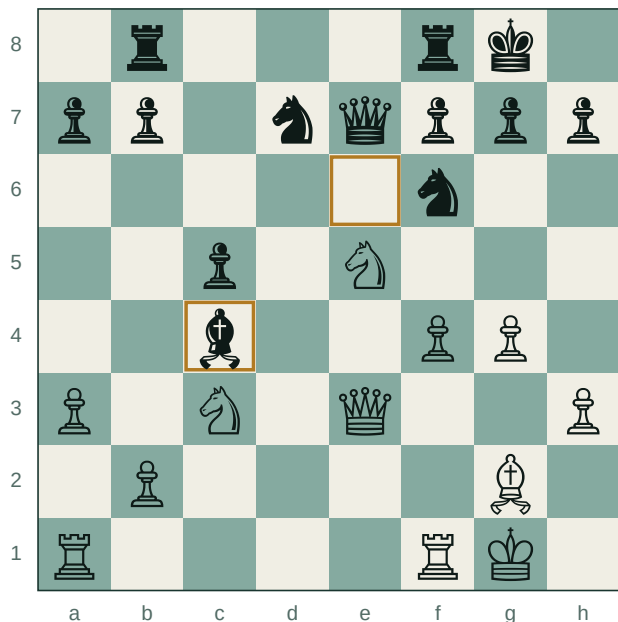


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 20

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 19...Bc4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20. Nxc4 Qxe3+ 21. Nxe3

20.Nxc4 The knight captures the bishop on c4. The changed line means the queen on e3 attacks the queen on e7.
Recorded reply: **20...Qxe3+**.

21.Nxe3 The knight captures the queen on e3.

At the end, nominal material is White 24 / Black 22 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: queen on e7 and bishop on c4. Check for tactical protection.